Chapter Three Outlines

The Report Structure

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Introduction

- Report writing described as a **career skill**. It can make a huge <u>difference</u> to how you are **perceived** and even how well you **get on** in your career.
- Good communication skills and ability to write effective reports are **essential competencies** for <u>every</u> **successful businessperson**.

To fail to prepare is to prepare to fail.

Introduction

Before you write a single word you must:

- **Set your objective.**
- **Assess your readership.**
- **Decide what information you will need.**
- **Prepare your skeletal framework.**
- **Test and revise your skeletal framework.**

Planning Phase

Preparing The Skeletal Framework

The overall plan of report =

The **skeletal framework**

- It shows its overall **structure,** it will also **remind** you of **information** you will need to **gather** before the **process of construction** can begin.
- A number of **significant benefits** will increase in constructing a skeletal framework. **In particular, it will enable the writer to:**

Preparing The Skeletal Framework

- **have an overview of the entire report,**
- **identify any gaps in coverage or logic,**
- **be sure there is no misunderstanding over the Terms of Reference,**
- **order his thoughts before considering how they should be expressed,**
- **be reminded of what information must be collected, what is already available and what is not needed,**
- **appreciate significance of / relationship between items of information,** *and*
- **maintain a sense of perspective while gathering information and, later, when writing the report.**

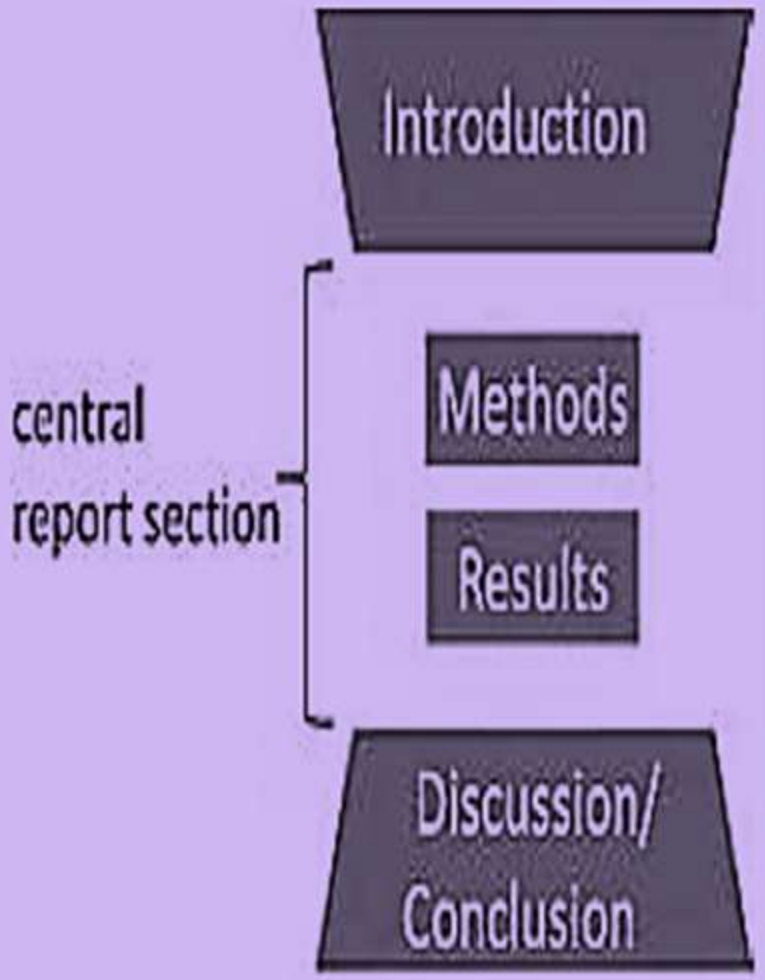
Preparing The Skeletal Framework

- **A well-planned skeletal framework is the key to effective report writing.** There are **three stages** involved in the preparation of a skeletal framework:

  - Write a **working title.**
  - **Consider the overall structure of the report.**
  - Consider how **information** will be presented **within the main body.**

Preparing The Skeletal Framework

- ***The Beginning***
  - Title page
  - Foreword
  - Preface
  - Acknowledgements
  - Contents page
  - Summary or Abstract
  - Introduction
- ***The Middle***
  - Main body, including substructures
- ***The End***
  - Conclusions
  - Recommendations
  - Appendixes
  - References
  - Bibliography
  - Glossary
  - Index



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The Beginning Sections

Title Page (cover)

- The title.
- The name and position of the person who authorized the report.
- The name of the author(s).
- His position within organization.
- The organization name and logo.
- The date the report was issued.
- A reference number.
- Copyright information, *if necessary.*
- Its degree of confidentiality.
- The distribution list.

The Beginning Sections

Foreword

Preface

Acknowledgements

Contents Page

The Beginning Sections

Summary or Abstract or Synopsis

Useful when you have a diverse readership. It has two main functions:

- To provide a precis of what the recipient is about to read or has just read.
- To provide an outline of the report if the recipient is not going to read the entire report.

The Beginning Sections

Summary or Abstract or Synopsis

A summary *could* contain just five paragraphs:

- **Intention** (your purpose and scope)
- **Outline** (what was done and how it was done)
- **Main findings**
- **Main conclusions**
- **Main recommendations** (if necessary).

The Beginning Sections

Introduction

- **Sets the scene. Tells the reader what it is all about. A good introduction will engage the readers' interest and include everything that they will need to know before moving on to the main body of the report.**
- **It will contain certain essential preliminaries which would not be weighty enough individually to justify headings of their own. *These might include*:**
- **Why** was the report written? **Who** requested it, and **when**?
- What were your **terms of reference**?

The Beginning Sections

Introduction

- What **resources** were **available** to you? (*e.g*. staff, time and equipment.)
- What **limitations**, if any, did you work under? What were the **reasons** for this? (***e.g***. **'The report does not analyze departmental expenditure in June because the figures were not available.')**
- What **information sources** did you use? **How** did you **obtain** this information?

The Beginning Sections

Introduction

- What **working methods**? A technical report will require a technical explanation of methods used. *(Some writers provide this in an appendix.)*

- **How is the report structured**? **Why** did you choose this method of presentation? This explanation helps your readers find their way around the report and shows the logic of the layout.

Conclusions

Conclusions should always be:

- clearly and simply stated
- objective and not exaggerated
- written with the likely impact on the reader clearly in mind.

The End Sections

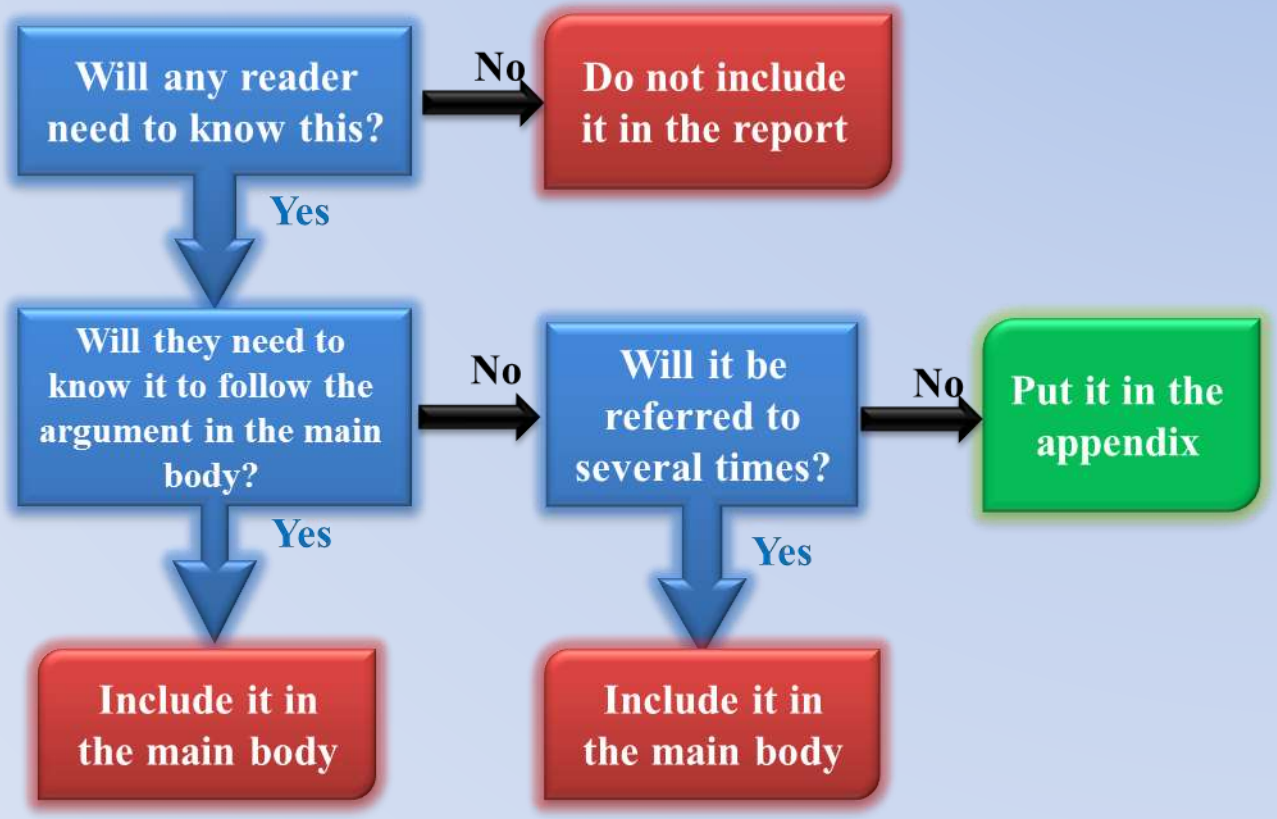
Recommendations

- Your recommendations should follow logically from your conclusions.
  - Effective recommendations are concise and to the point.
  - Your recommendations must also be realistic.
  - Think carefully about the suggestions of all your recommendations

The End Sections

Appendixes

It is a way of providing adequate detail for readers who require it without breaking the thread of the main body.



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The End Sections

References

- This section provides full details of various information sources *such as*; articles, books, journals, web sites… etc. specifically mentioned in the text, or from which extracts have been quoted.
- They should be listed in the same order as referred to in the report.

- Some report writers prefer to use footnotes rather than a reference section.

The End Sections

References

Books

Audrey Segal *Careers Encyclopaedia,* 25th ed., Cassell (2005) or, *Careers Encyclopaedia,* Audrey Segal (Cassell, 25th edition, 2005)

Information from Internet

Daniela Ibarra, (2016), Effective Presentation Skills: 4 Steps, available at: [https://www.bizlibrary.com/article/effective-presentation-skills-4-steps/] Last Access (6/2/2019).

Journals recorded in this way:

J.F.C. KINGMAN 'On the Algebra of Queues', *Methuen's Review Series in Applied Probability,* Vol 6, pp. 1-44 (1966).

The End Sections

Bibliography

- A bibliography also gives full details of every publication referred to in the text.
- It is useful when you have a diverse readership since you can provide separate lists for background or further reading and recommended reading.
- Details of publications are given in the same format as are references, but it is customary to list them alphabetically by the author surname or by the book title.

The End Sections

Glossary

- A glossary is necessary when you have used a good deal of <u>specialized</u> or <u>technical vocabulary</u>.

- Make sure your definitions are authoritative, precise and up-to-date.

- List the words alphabetically and place the section towards the report end.

The End Sections

Index

- An index is necessary only for a large report.
- It should contain more entries than a contents page and it is perfectly acceptable for it to be presented in two or three columns.
- List items alphabetically.
- Some words are spelt the same way but have different meanings. **Make sure your index reflects the word true *meaning*.**

The End Sections

Index

INDEX

The meaning of a word, *and*
The context in which it is used.

A

abstracts, *see* summaries

accessing information (*see also* information technology), 50-2

accident reports, 167

acknowledgements (*see also* copyright), 21-2

agendas for committee meetings, 168-70

aims, 23, 24

alignment, type, 140-1

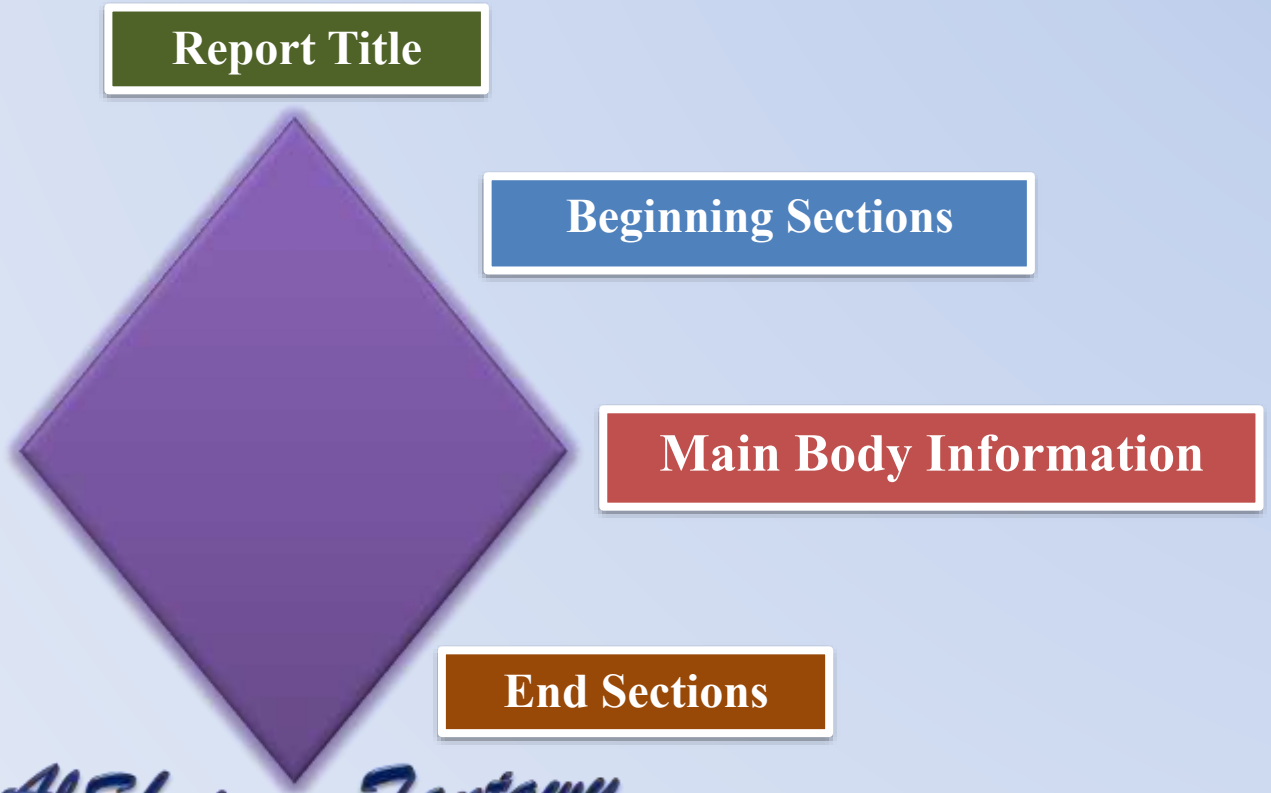
amending drafts, *see* checking

The Main Body

- The final step, consider how **information** should be **presented within the main body** **which contains** basic information, main ideas, required facts/data from all available and related sources.
- If you already mind mapped information you will need to obtain, you can now **re-shape** this material into a **structure** that **your readers** will find both ***acceptable*** and ***intelligible***.

The Main Body

Diagrammatic representation of the structure of a complete document



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The Main Body

Different levels of category must be organized into a *hierarchy,* with the title at the top of the hierarchy.

- **Level 1 Categories** are based on *the broad areas that are to be covered;*
- **Level 2 Categories** relate to the *more detailed findings* which *collectively* cover each of these broad areas.

The Main Body

In addition to the hierarchical organization, each module, or group of categories must be put into a *logical order.* Categories can be considered as one of two types:

- ***Verbs*** **(relating to sequences, actions, events)** *and*
- ***Nouns*** **(relating to people, places, ideas).**

The Main Body

Working Title:

Introducing Networks

***Or* (The Computer Networks)**

- **Using the network** (*types*, *advantages*… etc.)
- **Setting up your computer to use the network** (requirements)
- **Sharing your folders or printers** (benefits, usage… etc.)
- **Using resources located on other computers** (resources sharing)
- **Connecting to the Internet**. (The Web Connection)

Collecting and Handling Information

you are now ready to undertake your project or investigation.

These are the basic stages your research should follow:

- **Locate sources of relevant information.**
- **Obtain the information.**
- **Sort and group your findings.**
- **Evaluate your findings.**
- **Prioritize your findings.**
- **Check your findings.**

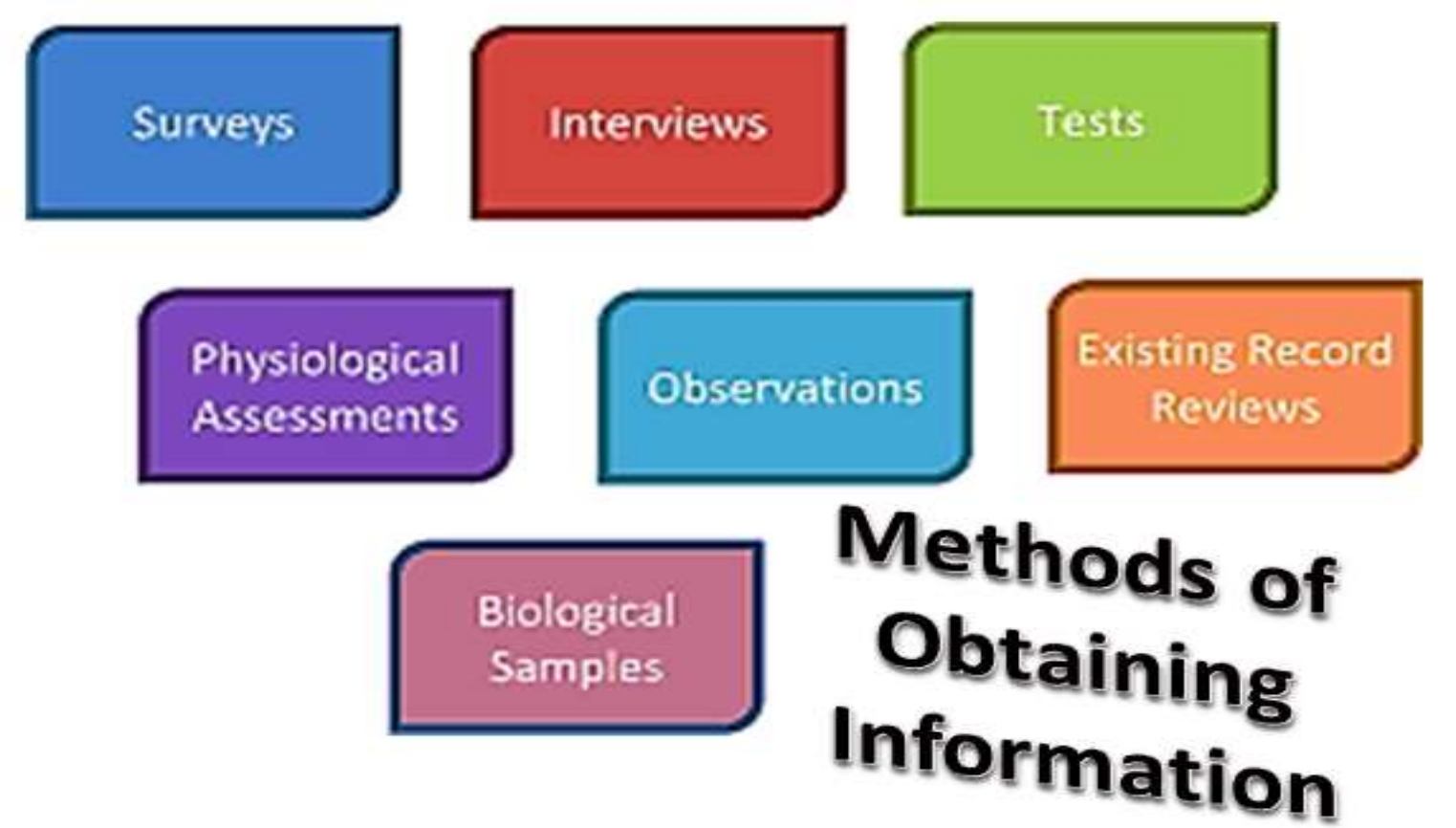
Locating Information

Commonly there are 4 main sources of information available to you:

1. **People**
2. **Books, Journals, articles, Organization Documents and other Publications**
3. **Information Technology Sources**
4. **Events and Places.**

Collecting and Handling Information

Gathering Information



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Collecting and Handling Information

- **Sorting and Grouping Information**
- **Evaluating Information**

  Accurate? Objective? Complete? Strong?
- **Prioritizing Information**
- **Checking Information**

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The Report Structure Revision

Seven Tests

Necessity Test

Inclusion Test

Exclusion Test

Hierarchy Test

Sequence Test

Language Test

Numbering Test

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The Report Structure Revision

These seven tests collectively provide a comprehensive, yet relatively simple writing tool. Important benefits will be accumulated from consistently applying them:

- They ensure the structural dependability of the text,
- They make the subsequent writing process much more straightforward, *and*
- They ensure that text will be easier to read and understand.